

The Argument for a Concentration-Based DIAP Requirement

Arenal Haut, Amiya Mandapati, Skyler Chong, Naomi Desalegne, Jewel Medel, Sarah Ogundare

A Very Short History and the Current State of DIAP

In 2016, a temporary committee of Brown students, faculty, and administration, was tasked with creating a list of recommendations for the Diversity and Inclusion Action Plan (DIAP) as it pertains to curriculum. One outcome of this process was a new course label, DIAP, which replaced the Diverse Perspectives in Liberal Learning (DPLL) stamp that had previously been used to describe courses that tackled issues of structural inequity and bias. DIAP courses continue to be used throughout the university. In order for a course to obtain this classification, it must investigate one or more of the following:

- “the ways different forms of power and privilege construct racial and identity formations in the U.S. and/or globally; the cultural, political, and intellectual responses to this racialization;
- the production of categories of ethnicity, race, gender, sexual orientation, class, religion, ability, citizenship status, and geography (and their intersections);
- the structures, institutions, practices, and attitudes that enable, maintain, or mitigate domestic and/or global disparities in health, income, education outcomes, media representations, etc.;
- the production of knowledge and difference in the context of discourses on race, power, and privilege.”¹

As part of their 2016 Report on Diversity in the Curriculum, members of the task force reviewed results from a Brown Daily Herald survey on a DIAP requirement. The survey showed that 58.4% of students agreed that DIAP courses should be required for all students.² Despite clear student support, the task force ultimately decided against recommending a DIAP requirement at that time, as they felt it would force students to take classes in which they had no interest.³ This decision would leave the vast majority of students at Brown without a meaningful understanding of racism, sexism, and other forms of inequality. However, the committee urged Brown to increase the number and visibility of diversity and inclusion-related opportunities, and to revise the curricular designation of DIAP.

In their working paper, “The Two Opposing Faces of Brown’s Liberal Learning Model,” Kanha Prasad ‘21 and Diego Rodriguez ‘21 summarize the rest of the suggestions in the 2016 Report on Diversity in the Curriculum as follows:

¹ “DIAP Courses: Race, Gender, and Inequality,” Brown University, accessed March 21, 2021, [https://www.brown.edu/academics/college/degree/DIAPcourses](https://www.brown.edu/academics/college/degree/degree/DIAPcourses).

² “Report of the Task Force on Diversity in the Curriculum,” Brown University, last modified August 2016, accessed March 12, 2021, <https://www.brown.edu/about/administration/institutional-diversity/sites/oidi/files/Task%20Force-Diversity%20in%20Curriculum-September-2016.pdf>.

³ “Report of the Task Force,” Brown University.

- “Create several large introductory survey courses (preferably team-taught) addressing issues of racial, economic, social, and cultural inequity in the United States and globally;
- Encourage all concentrations to provide meaningful engagement with issues of diversity and inclusion;
- Continue support for both First-Year and Sophomore Seminars that focus on power, privilege, and social justice, and assessment of both programs;
- Pending review and approval by the College Curriculum Council, replace “Diverse Perspectives in Liberal Learning” with a new curricular designation, “Race, Power, and Privilege” (RPP); develop a more robust review process within the College Curriculum Council;
- Enhance support and resources for instructors and teaching assistants on inclusive teaching strategies;
- Increase support for the Engaged Scholars Program;
- Reconvene a committee in three years to evaluate the progress made on the recommendations in this report.”⁴

These suggestions form the basis for current discussions regarding restructuring the Brown curriculum. Most notably, the first suggestion has remained unimplemented, in part due to the way that Brown requires courses to be created and hosted. Any course offered must be hosted by an existing department. Yet, the departments with the scholarship and experience to meaningfully teach these “large introductory survey courses addressing issues of racial, economic, social, and cultural inequity in the United States and globally” are small, among them American Studies, Ethnic Studies, and Africana Studies. While these departments are comprised of faculty and disciplines themselves that are committed to DIAP, to require them to take on the responsibility of providing DIAP courses for the whole undergraduate body would neither be feasible nor fair, and would disproportionately impact smaller departments and faculty of color.

Critically, the departments already doing the work of educating students about inequity will continue to do so, while those that believe they do not share this responsibility will continue to rely on these small departments to provide DIAP courses for the whole community.

Now, in 2021, the Brown community and the College Curriculum Council have revisited the role of race, power, and privilege in our curriculum, spurred by recent movements led by Black communities calling for the end of racial systems in facets of life from policing and housing to education and knowledge production.

⁴ Kanha Prasad and Diego Rodriguez, "The Two Opposing Faces of Brown's 'Liberal Learning' Model," 2021, 4, accessed March 19, 2021, https://docs.google.com/document/d/1x4opWJprLQa_XLGCobBikomozUPbGBcN3E_I62x760/edit.

Why We Need a Requirement/Importance of DIAP

Within this broader context, we view a DIAP requirement as necessary. As members of Decolonization at Brown, we recognize that a DIAP requirement by itself is not decolonization-- the material movement of wealth and power into Black and Indigenous communities-- yet the roles of colonialism, race, power, and privilege in our curriculum remain largely unaddressed. A requirement would be a more moderate step towards engaging with the ongoing effects of systems of oppression, including colonialism and racism, within concentrations at Brown. However, this systematic view of academia differs from pure diversity and inclusion work in that it actively requires us to acknowledge the current systems in place.

We hope this can be one way to fill the clear absence of systematic engagement with race, power, and privilege within the Brown undergraduate degree and student experience. While optional DIAP courses are a step forward, they do not ensure that Brown students graduate with a comprehensive understanding of how the acquisition – and perpetuation – of power and privilege permeate both their professional and personal lives. Without a DIAP requirement, the Brown community as a whole has struggled to consider how dominant, selective discourses uphold oppressive systems of power and suppress the narratives of marginalized communities in *all* fields of knowledge.

Though some might argue that a DIAP requirement could impinge on the freedom afforded by the Open Curriculum, it is important to consider why the WRIT requirement was proposed. It implies that, no matter the concentration, Brown regards writing to be an essential skill. Similarly, considering and understanding others' lived experiences and how they relate to one's specific field is vital, no matter the subject area. By implementing a DIAP requirement, Brown would be communicating that regardless of one's field, students should be aware of their field's history, their own biases, and the oppressive structures they risk upholding. In doing so, Brown would not only be acknowledging its complicity in broader systemic inequities; it would also equip every graduating student with the necessary background to recognize and critically confront systemic power dynamics in their work and lives after Brown. In this sense, implementing a DIAP requirement would not be a limitation of the open curriculum, but rather a supplementation and enhancement of it – further challenging students to expand their minds and academic practices.

Many students have had positive experiences with DIAP courses. Valerie Raquel Aguilar Dellisanti '23 shared, “[DIAP classes are] by far my favorite classes at Brown and made me pick up a second concentration. [They] definitely broaden my range of knowledge and make me discover other fields.”⁵ Yinessa Baez Gonzalez '24 noted that her DIAP class “[makes] sure that the students are having these conversations about race, gender, and inequality.... [It] doesn't shy away from the still ever-present problems of racism, sexism, misogyny, and so on.”⁶

There has been sustained student interest in conversations surrounding systems of oppression in the curriculum. Not only did Decolonization at Brown put out a school-wide

⁵ Valerie Raquel Aguilar Dellisanti, "Decolonization at Brown DIAP Survey," survey response, March 3, 2021.

⁶ Yinessa Baez Gonzalez, "Decolonization at Brown DIAP Survey," survey response, March 4, 2021.

survey this semester, but we have also held two teach-ins: Colonialism in the Curriculum (with the departments of Africana Studies and American Studies) in October 2019, drawing over 120 students, staff, and faculty; and Colonialism in STEM in February 2021, drawing over 180. In our survey of Brown's undergraduate class with a 4.7% response rate, over 71% of students expressed support for a DIAP requirement in some form. Angel Rodriguez '21 stated, "Brown is supposed to be a university that builds and fosters future leaders of the world, and in order for that to be most effective, I think it's important to understand how power and structural inequalities influences not only the day to day interactions of the general public and our peers, but also how it may unconsciously influence what our career decisions and life look like post-graduation. I think the current structure makes it so people who are already questioning and thinking about these dynamics enter these classes, while those who may benefit the most from this education are either unaware of the offering, what can be learned, or how important the material discussed is. [T]here is a misconception that courses that talk about these issues are not useful for those in STEM related fields, but by making it a graduation requirement... it would encourage people to see how they may intersect."⁷ Given that students overwhelmingly support a DIAP requirement, it is necessary to consider how to best implement it. Namely, would a general or a concentration requirement be most beneficial?

General Requirement

DIAP classes are valuable because race, power, and privilege influence every part of our lives, but many students-- often those with the most privilege-- have never explored how these topics affect their lives and others. One option for more students Brown to learn about these important concepts would be to have a general university requirement for a DIAP course, similar to the WRIT requirement. This requirement would allow all students to explore race, power, and privilege and to apply skills such as critical thinking, social consciousness, and self-awareness to their lives. Additionally, whenever these topics are brought up, students without lived experience will lean on those who do to teach them. In this way, students of color are pressured to perform the emotional labor of educating their white peers about race and privilege. A general requirement would help take the weight off students of color from having to teach other students about these topics. In addition, a university-wide requirement reinforces the message that diversity and inclusion are essential to students' futures in the world.

Nonetheless, there are some complications with having a university-wide general DIAP requirement, some of which would negatively impact students and faculty of color. Particularly, one concern is that having a university-wide requirement goes against the Open Curriculum. This would lead to many students taking a DIAP class just to get the requirement out of the way without having any interest in the topics, and without benefiting from the knowledge that comes out of these classes. Additionally, having a general DIAP requirement with the current DIAP course offerings would put enormous strain on the departments that already teach about race, power, and privilege, because they currently host the majority of the classes with the DIAP

⁷ Angel Rodriguez, "Decolonization at Brown DIAP Survey," survey response, March 3, 2021.

‘stamp.’ So if students were to fulfill a DIAP requirement, they would flood already-overworked departments that offer those classes, saddling a small percentage of teaching faculty with the work of educating all Brown’s undergraduates. In addition, many of the professors in these departments are younger, untenured professors of color. Filling such classes with students solely aiming to fulfill a requirement may lead to disproportionately negative reviews and evaluations of these professors from students who do not enjoy the material. This added stress might detrimentally affect their eligibility for promotions and tenure.

Another reason against a general DIAP requirement would be that forcing students to take classes they are not interested in would hurt the marginalized students in those classes. Disengaged students in spaces where the material may already be difficult to discuss may change the classroom dynamic-- potentially negatively impacting both students and professors from marginalized communities. Even among students supporting the requirement, such as Allison Singleton ‘22, there are concerns that classes that were once enjoyable would become a “living hell for students whose identity is tied to the coursework.”⁸ Many of these problems that might be seen with a general requirement could be fixed with professors of all concentrations and departments teaching DIAP classes that align with their curriculum. In the survey taken of students about their views on a DIAP requirement, many said that they would only support a requirement if course offerings were expanded into different fields, like a concentration-specific requirement would do.

Concentration Requirement

While thinking about how to address the concerns surrounding a general DIAP general requirement, many of DAB’s discussions with faculty and students have turned to the idea of a concentration-specific requirement. In many ways the arguments for this type of requirement mirror the cons of a general requirement.

As Prasad and Rodriguez point out in their paper, a general requirement would put a much greater burden onto departments such as American Studies, Africana Studies, Ethnic Studies, and History that are already more focused on critiquing systems of race and injustice and offering DIAP courses. Students would not increase their understanding of systems of oppression as they pertain to their own fields, future work, and entire lives. Furthermore, if all students were required to take a DIAP class in a department they are not interested in, it would degrade the level of engagement and community that is found in these spaces.

A concentration-specific requirement would address all of these issues by allowing students to learn about how issues of diversity and inclusion intersect with their field of interest, while also distributing the responsibility of creating DIAP courses evenly among departments. This would better elucidate the interconnectedness between disciplines and how they have historically contributed to the development and reproduction of systemic racism and injustice, thus showing students that their work does not exist in a vacuum, no matter what they might

⁸ Allison Singleton, "Decolonization at Brown DIAP Survey," survey response, March 3, 2021.

concentrate in. Faculty and students will be able to take charge of their own curriculum, and work together to find a model that works best for them.

We acknowledge that this will not be an overnight process: some departments will need more support in creating DIAP classes, while others may already be meeting our expectations. However, we believe that with work and time, a concentration requirement is not only attainable but the best way to ensure that all students are getting the most out of their education here at Brown.

Suggestions and Intermediate Steps

In order to effectively implement a concentration-specific DIAP requirement, many changes would need to be made and the process would undoubtedly need to be discussed and thought through in greater detail. However, in our work as a task force, we have come across a variety of additional suggestions that we think relate to a DIAP requirement, both at a concentration/departmental level and in terms of diversity and inclusion more broadly.

Teaching models:

In their aforementioned paper, Prasad and Rodriguez provide detailed descriptions of three different models that would address the university's failure to meet the 2016 DIAP Report's first suggestion: the creation of "several large introductory survey courses (preferably team-taught) addressing issues of racial, economic, social, and cultural inequity in the United States and globally," specifically at the concentration level. The models they highlighted were: co-teaching, guest lecturing, and the hiring of students for curriculum development. These models are not mutually exclusive and we believe that if combined skillfully, they can allow departments to quickly develop meaningful DIAP courses while making sure that the responsibility to create these spaces does not fall entirely onto a select few departments or even a select few professors within each department.

Popular large lecture courses that serve as introductions to a discipline have often taken this approach, such as "Equilibrium, Rate, and Structure" in Chemistry. Having a team of faculty members representing different teaching styles, expertises in the field, and perspectives on the subject matter can be extremely valuable at the introductory course level. Guest lecturing could also be successfully implemented, either by utilizing professors from different departments, or by hosting visiting scholars to lecture about a particular topic.

Successful implementation of a DIAP requirement would necessitate policies such as cluster-hiring scholars, post-docs, and professors who are trained in fields related to racialization, colonialism, etc., as well as providing more support for them in terms of seeking tenure.

Inclusion of DIAP in existing classes:

Including DIAP content in pre-existing introductory courses or other required courses could serve as an intermediate step in creating more diverse, stand-alone DIAP courses for concentrations. However, this material should not be presented as a one-stop destination where students learn about DIAP and immediately move on.

Another method of incorporating DIAP into existing classes would be to mimic the model used in CS classes with Socially Responsible Computing Teaching Assistants (STAs). In this model, student TAs are tasked with working with professors to “repeatedly expose students to the social, political, and ethical aspects of computing and directly relate these issues to technical choices.”⁹ While the language would need to be worked out further to suit each department, this model provides a concrete example of how DIAP can be woven into an existing class, while also introducing a structure for compensating students for the hard work they are doing in their communities.

Strengthening the requirements for a DIAP course designation:

In addition to expanding the DIAP course offerings, we have also heard from multiple sources that the requirements and approval process for DIAP courses must be strengthened. The review process conducted at the CCC to accept requests to use DIAP designation is taken seriously, but the requirements remain rather flexible and the number of applications heavily depend on faculty enthusiasm rather than administrative incentive.

Conclusion

As members of Decolonization at Brown, we recognize that a DIAP requirement is not about decolonization, but rather engaging with the ongoing effects of systems of oppression--including colonialism and racism-- within concentrations at Brown. We believe that the Brown community has a responsibility to make this modification to the Open Curriculum, so that the student body is not limited to learning the history and intellectual practices of a small subset of the world. It's essential for every graduating Brown student to be equipped with an understanding of historical and present-day systems of oppression and how they impact every field.

Acknowledgements

We would like to thank Diego Rodriguez and Kanha Prasad for granting us permission to use parts of their paper in our work, Jai'el Toussaint for his help in editing and coordinating, Junaid Malik for mentoring us and guiding us through this process, and the Decolonization at Brown Steering Committee for supporting our work from start to finish. Additional thanks go to

⁹ Socially Responsible Computing TA Program, last modified January 2021, accessed March 23, 2021, <http://ethics.cs.brown.edu/>.

Valerie Raquel Aguilar Dellisanti, Yinessa Baez Gonzalez, Angel Rodriguez, and Allison Singleton for allowing us to use their survey responses.